



Country fun

With its sharp tusks, the wild boar was a dangerous animal to hunt

IN THE COUNTRYSIDE around Shakespeare's home town of Stratford, people made their own entertainment when they had the opportunity. They kicked footballs made from inflated pigs' bladders, practiced archery, and played simple board games. The wild creatures from the surrounding fields and forests provided locals with sports, as well as meat for their tables. The poor hunted small birds and animals, while the wealthy preferred to chase larger prey such as wild boar and deer in the forests. Deer could also be found in Sir Thomas Lucy's private park at Charlecote, five miles (eight kilometers) east of Stratford.

DOST THOU LOVE HAWKING?

A lord in *The Taming of the Shrew* asks the question "Dost thou love hawking?" Shakespeare certainly did, and he mentions it more often in his plays than he does any other sport. When the heroine of *Romeo and Juliet* wants to call back her departing lover, she cries, "O! for a falconer's voice, to lure this tassel-gentle back again." A "tassel-gentle" was a name for a male peregrine falcon.

Slow, strong mastiff dog, used to kill wild boars



Bloodhound, used to sniff out wild boar and deer

HUNTING HOUNDS

There were various types of hunting dog, each one bred for a different purpose. Greyhounds were bred for speed. In *Henry VI Part Three*, Queen Margaret compares the enemies pursuing her to two greyhounds: "Edward and Richard, like a brace of greyhounds having the fearful fleeing hare in sight ... are at our backs."



Swift greyhound, used for coursing (running after hares)

The hood stopped the bird from flying away

Gyr Falcon



Hunting

Hunting and falconry (hunting using birds of prey) were popular pastimes for rich and poor alike. Nobles kept peregrine falcons and gyr falcons, which they used to catch herons, ducks, pigeons, and rooks. Poorer people kept goshawks, which were thought to be less noble birds. Goshawks were flown after hares, rabbits, and partridges.



Hare, used mainly for its meat

The falconer gripped the jesses, or leather straps, attached to the bird's legs

Jingling bells allowed the falconer to find the bird when it went out of sight

A heavy glove protected the hand from the bird's sharp talons